ABC Observation Diary

What happened before / what happened / what happened afterward

This diary can help you notice patterns and discuss them with a professional. One entry cannot establish the “function of behavior” or replace a medical or functional assessment.

How to complete the diary

1. Write down the event soon afterward: date, place and observable actions, without labels such as “manipulative”.
2. Describe what happened immediately before and afterward. If something is unknown, say so.
3. Note how the child seemed afterward and what helped, if you could observe it. Do not deliberately trigger an incident.

Completed example

Situation: a writing task in a noisy classroom. This is a teaching example, not data from a real child.

A • Before	The teacher handed out worksheets and asked the children to write independently for about 20 minutes. The classroom was noisy.
B • Behavior	A few minutes later, the child shouted, pushed away the sheet and threw a pencil.
C • After	An adult stopped the task and helped the child move to a quieter place.

How the child seemed afterward: not described in this example. In a real entry, note this if possible.

What this entry does NOT establish

The task stopped, the noise decreased and an adult helped at the same time. One entry cannot prove that the child shouted “to escape the task”. Do not withhold help or breaks to test that assumption.

Safety and privacy. If there is pain, a sudden change in condition or risk of injury, ensure safety first and seek appropriate help. Do not include unnecessary personal details. Keep the diary confidential.

Read more: Functional behavior assessment - AutismHub

ABC Observation Form

One event per sheet. Print this page again as needed or fill it in Word.

Date and approximate time	Location / situation
Who was nearby (if relevant)	**Health / environmental conditions before the event (if known)**

What happened?

A	**BEFORE the event** What happened immediately beforehand? Instructions, noise, waiting, a change.
B	**BEHAVIOR** What exactly did you see or hear? Do not guess intentions.
C	**AFTER the event** What did others do? What changed immediately afterward?

What happened next?

How did the child seem afterward? What helped (if known)?
Other relevant details: sleep, pain, noise, routine changes, similar calm situations (if known)

Reminder. Record what you observed. An ABC diary can help discuss patterns, but it cannot establish the cause of behavior by itself. Do not create unsafe situations to collect observations.